



Effects of Diffusion

Changing Cultures

- People of different cultures interact (cultural convergence)
 - What is the result?
 - Assimilation
 - Acculturation
 - Multiculturalism
 - Transculturation
 - Syncretism



MyFreePPT

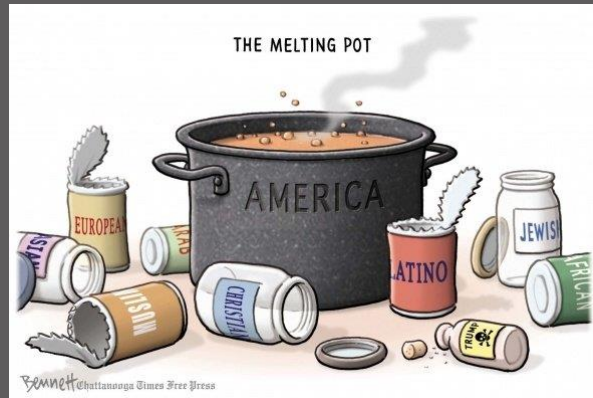
Culture includes language, beliefs (religion and values/mentifacts), clothing, behaviors (sociofacts), food preferences, and every single learned behavior we have. We do not leave our culture behind when we move to a new location – we take it with us.

When a migrant (or group of migrants) move into a new area that is already populated, there WILL be cultural change that occurs due to cultural convergence. The minority culture (usually the immigrants unless they outnumber those already occupying the space, such as with the case of colonization of the Americas) will likely change the most; however, how much change takes place often depends on the amount of time that passes and what the expectations are in the new location.

The outcome of this change can be classified as one of 5 forms, each discussed on the pages that follow

Assimilation

- Complete adoption of the more dominant culture



Assimilation is a process whereby people of a culture learn to adapt to the ways of the majority culture. There is a loss of one's own culture as a person gives more value to the cultural aspects of the majority community in the process of assimilation.

Assimilation is the total/complete/absolute adoption of the more dominant culture by the migrants.

Pre-1970s Northeastern U.S. is a good example of where assimilation occurred. During this time, the vast majority of immigrants were coming to the U.S. from Western Europe. Migrants entering the U.S. were expected to follow quickly learn to speak English, be Protestant Christians, sound like an American (speaking American Standard English), etc. They were expected to eat American foods, observe American holidays, and have attitudes and behaviors that reflect American values. Migrants worked hard to meet the expectations of the "Great American Melting Pot" (melting into American culture and losing an independent cultural identity that was different).

Assimilation was so complete that almost all traces of the migrant's original culture are lost. People no longer knew where their families came from. This is one reason those DNA testing kits are so popular – today, people want to know where they come from and are finding they were completely wrong in what they thought they knew of their family history!

Acculturation

- Some aspects of original culture remains
 - Adopts enough of dominant culture to participate in society



MyFreePPT

If you belong to a minority community in a country and retain your own culture but cannot remain isolated and are affected by the majority culture in such a way that you adapt to some aspects of the majority culture, the process is referred to as acculturation.

With acculturation, **some** of the migrant's original culture remains – usually religion and food preferences (these two things are very difficult to change). The migrants move into an area, and while they may learn to speak the language of the dominant culture and dress like the dominant culture, they may continue to practice their own religions, observe those holidays, and eat their preferred foods (at least at home).

Today, recent immigrants are more likely to **acculturate** rather than assimilate – migration patterns have changed, as well, and there are many more people of non-European cultures present in the United States today than prior to the 1960s, particularly from South and East Asia, so the difference is much more visible on the cultural landscape of the U.S.

Multiculturalism

- Multiple culture groups occupy the same geographic area
 - Results from process of territory expansion or migration



MyFreePPT

Multiculturalism is sometimes referred to as cultural pluralism (multiple cultures). It is a term used when smaller groups within a larger society maintain their unique cultural identities, and their values and practices are accepted by the wider dominant culture provided they are consistent with the laws and values of the wider society.

The United States and Canada today are considered “multicultural societies” – both were formed as their territories expanded to include land occupied by people of another culture (i.e., British Canada expanded to include Quebec (French Canada), and the U.S. expanded to include the Southwest and the Spanish Catholics that that occupied that territory) as well as by accepting immigrants from many cultures around the world – particularly since the 1960s and 1970s.

Multiculturalism referenced as a “salad bowl” rather than a melting pot – the different bits are still identifiable, but each ingredient together compliments and enhances the other.

Transculturation

- Transmission across cultures
 - “the merging and converging” of two cultures
 - Two-way cultural exchange



MyFreePPT

Transculturation can be explained by breaking down the term “trans” means “across” and of course, “culture” means “culture”. – transmission across cultures.

Transculturation is a term used to describe cultural convergence. It is the greater transmission of cultural traits across cultures rather than a one-way transmission found with acculturation or assimilation. In transculturation, the exchange goes both ways, so the result is seen in both groups as their two cultures merge.

To explain the difference between assimilation/acculturation and transculturation, I will use a single example: That of the colonist into the Americas.

The Spanish conquistadors and colonist came with the intent of “Gold, God, and Glory”, so the natives were rounded up and made to assimilate to the Spanish culture (complete adoption of Spanish beliefs, language, etc.). Here’s the thing with that – full assimilation takes several generations as mentifacts don’t change so easily. What actually happened with that first group of conquered natives (those that survived the European diseases such as small pox and measles, that is) was a forced acculturation – the natives outwardly displayed the Spanish culture (Catholic Christian and Spanish speaking), but inwardly kept elements of their own culture.

Over time, the Spanish colonists started picking up some of the cultural traits of the natives – they learned new words for the flora (plants) and fauna (animals) that were native to the Americas. They adopted and shared with their home country many of the agricultural products that have been domesticated by the Natives (corn, beans, chili peppers, squash, etc.) that then became staples (common food sources) of the Spanish (and European) diets. This transmission of culture from the Spanish to the Natives and the Natives back to the Spanish is **Transculturation**.

Eventually, this cultural exchange became such an engrained part of the culture of Latin America that new cultural traits emerged that were a blend of the Spanish and Native cultures (discussed next slide)

Syncretism

- combination of separate concepts into one new, unique idea.



Syncretism is a combination of separate concepts into one new, unique idea. This concept was discussed with Syncretic religions or practices. Elements of the two cultures are combined into something new that is unique to the place where the two cultures converged.

Dia de los Muertos was an example used for a syncretized religious celebration – the merging of the Natives celebration of the dead with the Spanish Catholic tradition of All Saints Day (celebrated November 1) to create a new religious holiday that honors all deceased loved ones on the day following the feast of the saints (November 2).

Syncretism happens outside of religion, too, and is evident all through American culture. American food is a great example of cultural syncretism. Most American foods originated in other nations, like pizza, tacos, and egg rolls, and what's more, we have made most of them even more syncretic now: Mexican fajita toppings on pizza, and Asian tacos, etc. with so called "fusion" foods. American music is also a result of cultural syncretism. Jazz was originally a combination of German parade music, Brazilian beats, and elements of the blues. The Blues were already syncretic as they developed out of mixed African (slaves) and European traditions in the American south.

Orthodoxy is the opposite of syncretism – Orthodox means "purity", so in terms of religious syncretism, the orthodox branch of a religion would fight against the development of these new syncretized aspects of a religion and teach the "original" form only.

Pictured above: cultural syncretism in food form – "curry burrito" (left) and Tex-Mex pizza (pizza with corn, tomatoes, taco meat, cilantro, and salsa).

Changing Sense of Place



- Placelessness
- Placemaking

Changing sense of place occurs when the culture of one place spreads and takes over the cultural landscape of another. The rapid spread of global (popular) culture is destructive to sense of place. As consumer-based postmodern landscapes form, they are built over the existing traditional landscapes that previously existed. Unfortunately, what's being sold is typically mass-produced popular culture.

How can you tell the difference between an apartment complex in one place compared to an apartment complex in another? What about a Best Buy/Walmart/Target/HEB/Old Navy/Home Depot shopping center? They all look the same and due to brand recognition, the signs are all the same, too. There is no longer a unique sense of place in that geographic location.

Placemaking, however, strengthens the connection people have to the locations/place (s) they inhabit. These locations will reflect the culture and traditions of its inhabitants. EX. The architecture will be reflective of its inhabitants. As opposed to placelessness, it is a location with human and physical characteristics that distinguish it from other places.

Placelessness is the term used to describe the lost sense of place that occurs due to mass production (of housing, buildings, products, etc.) and the development of a postmodern consumer cultural landscape.

Changing Sense of Place

- Cultural Commodification



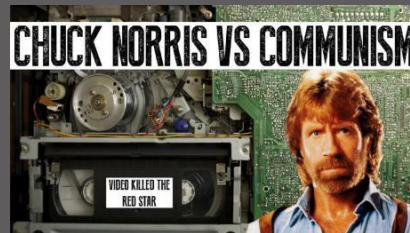
a **Commodity** is a raw material or primary agricultural product that can be bought and sold, such as copper or coffee.

Cultural Commodification refers to “selling” a place's culture and the cultural artifacts to make a large enough profit to support part of the area's economy. The culture itself becomes a tourist attraction and, often, as a result becomes a caricature of reality as they are changed and modified to suit the desires of the tourists – a Disnified (Disney-fied) version, if you will.

Instead of cultural rituals or foods being used for special occasions/celebrations, they are turned into a commodity, and tickets are sold to tourists to participate in the event. Examples include Luaus in Hawaii, examples from the Bali case study, etc.

Challenging Government Systems

- Cultural diffusion spreads *ideas*
 - Democracy
 - Equal rights
- Some countries push back against “Western” ideas
 - Protective legislation
 - Political barriers to diffusion



Culture not only spreads language, and religion, but also ideas – and some places work very hard to keep certain ideas from spreading into their area.

For example, during the Cold War (1940s-1991), the Soviet Union (USSR) had very strict laws about what movies and media could be brought into the country. The fear was that if their citizens saw the luxury and opulence of “The West” in these forms, they would want that as well – the Communist government of the USSR managed all factory production and goods distribution – people were assigned jobs and houses, rather than choosing their profession and their own home. Groceries were rationed – each person got so much of each staple product. There were very few luxuries. Blue jeans were contraband* not available except on the black market and were (the informal economy that operates outside of legal channels, and so in this sense, blue jeans were comparable to illegal drugs). People in American movies and TV often wear blue jeans and are trend setters (hierarchical diffusion!), they have swimming pools, live in large houses and apartments, etc. This was contrary to the reality of life in the Soviet Realm (USSR and surrounding countries under their political and economic influence). In class this week, we will be watching an interview of two women featured in the documentary “Chuck Norris vs. Communism” – the documentary is based on a woman who worked with smugglers to bring Hollywood movies into Romania (a Soviet Realm country) and dubbed them into Romanian (every character, every line) so that they could be seen by Romanian citizens. This activity was illegal as was viewing the movies – but they did it anyway. Eventually the democratic and free market ideas spread enough into the region that the citizens DID demand change. The people revolted in 1989 and overthrew the communist government of Romania. People in other countries followed suit – Czechoslovakia broke up into the Czech Republic and Slovakia, and (most famously), East and West Germany tore down the Berlin wall and Germany reunited as one country. The USSR officially disbanded in 1991, breaking into Russia and now-independent former Soviet states.

More recently, social media has been given credit as an important factor in the Arab Spring, which was a series of protests, uprisings, and armed rebellions that spread across the Middle East and North Africa in the 2010s - In the news, social media was heralded as the driving force behind the swift spread of revolution throughout the world, as new protests appear in response to success stories shared from those taking place in other countries. As a result, in many countries, the governments have also recognized the importance of social media for organizing and have shut down certain social media sites or blocked Internet service entirely as an attempt to thwart the efforts of the protestors.

Some countries almost completely restrict access to outside media, such as North Korea. Other countries, such as China, have strict censors in place and limit what social media and internet sources the people have access to. There is no facebook in China (legally, anyway). People have been arrested for having WhatsApp on their phones. If you share ideas or information that is contrary to the government, you could be arrested or even executed. In the world of academic geography, there is a very well known example right now – a well known professor and head of Xinjiang University in China has been missing for over a year. It is suspected that he was arrested and convicted of “separatism” and possibly will be or has already been executed for speaking critically of the communist government’s treatment of Muslims and minority ethnic groups (news article <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-china-49956088>)

Why do some governments put such strict limits on the diffusion of ideas into their country?

Information (and therefore culture/ideas) must be controlled in order for the current government to maintain their power. In authoritative governments, having control of the economy, culture, and other aspects of life is vital to their existence. If they don’t maintain control, events like what happened in the former USSR and Romania could happen in their country.

*contraband means goods that have been imported or exported illegally (smuggled into the country)

Centripetal forces

- Nationality
- Sports
 - Olympics
 - World Cup



Culture can bond us together – even if we come from diverse backgrounds, ethnicities, education levels, religions, etc. We find a sense of belonging with others who share our passions and desires. This is how aspects of culture are centripetal forces in nature. Within your school, you have a bond with other students experiencing the same thing as you – you’re all working through AP Human Geography together, experiencing the struggles, the Vocab Checks, the notes – and as you do them or when you’re done, you immediately want to talk about it (but remember, you are NOT allowed to talk about quizzes or exams until your teachers return them to you!!!). The same thing happens at a more “zoomed out” scale – where then are big national sporting events, such as the World Cup, people bond with others who are cheering for their same team. In Global sporting events, nations come together to cheer for the athletes representing them, such as the Olympics (Go Team USA!) or the World’s Cup. These events don’t take place every year, but the build up to them and the finals are exciting and are some of the most-watched TV broadcasts during year.

(side note – these major events cost billions of dollars and often divert resources from other marginalized populations, especially when they take place in less developed or newly industrialized countries)

Centrifugal Forces

- Cultural Conflict
 - Linguistic
 - Religious
 - Interfaith
 - Intrafaith



MyFreePPT

Culture can also divide populations – especially if there is a clear regional difference. When one particular area of a country is culturally (and ethnically) different, it is a dividing force within that country. When the two groups are unequal within society, the problem is magnified.

The example of Belgium was given in the Diffusion of Language notes – Belgium is an example of how centrifugal forces play out due to linguistic difference – particularly when combined with economic and social differences. Flanders had historically been the more agrarian, economically weaker part of the country so French-speaking Wallonia assumed power. Now that Flanders has been able to tap into the post-industrial high-tech economy, Wallonia is the region that is economically weaker. The French speakers, however, have the power and pass legislation in their favor. The Flemish of Flanders do not like this legislation, so they are pushing back against it and for self-rule (where the Flemish speakers have control to govern themselves – more on this topic in the Political unit).

Power and control of the resources (money, raw materials, trade – whatever the resource is) is almost always the root cause of conflict. Culture (language and religion in particular) are often used as rallying cries to create an “us vs. them” condition that leads to sometimes violent conflict.

Next class, groups will be doing research on different cultural conflicts. You will be responsible for knowing some of the details of each (to be shared after class). They are also in your book:

Linguistic Conflicts:

Belgium (p. 145)

Canada (p. 149)

Religious Conflicts

- **interfaith** – conflict along the boundaries of two different religions

Israel and Palestinians (Judaism and Islam – pg. 201)

Nigeria (Islam, Christianity, and tribal religions – pg. 204)

- **Intrafaith** – conflict along the boundaries of different branches within the SAME religion

Northern Ireland (Protestant Northern Ireland and Catholic Republic of Ireland pg. 205)

The map above shows the boundary between Islamic North Africa and Christian/traditional Sub-Saharan Africa. Many religious conflicts have taken place along this interfaith boundary (boundary between the two different religions – it is also on page 201 of your book if you would like a larger and clearer picture).

Fundamentalism

- Fundamentalism
 - Belief in complete authority of a religious text or teachings



MyFreePPT

Religious fundamentalism refers to the belief of in the absolute authority of a sacred religious text or teachings of a particular religious leader, prophet, and/ or God. Fundamentalism often develops out of a perception of the breakdown of a society's morals and values – that the society has become to “secular” and therefore needs to return to a more devout culture.

Fundamentalist exist in ALL religions.

The political (not political in this case) is social commentary in response to Christian fundamentalists who feel the U.S. society needs to return to more closely follow the teachings found in the Bible (religious text of Christianity). The pharmacy in this cartoon shows the rejection of modern science and is only selling medical remedies that were around during Biblical times (the time period during which the events described in the Bible occur).

Religious Extremism

- Fundamentalism to the point of violence
- Terrorism for political goals
 - Increase authority of religious



MyFreePPT

Religious extremist or fundamental extremist take fundamentalism to the level of violence. These are groups that are associated with terrorism.

Terrorism is the unlawful use of violence and intimidation, especially against civilians, in the pursuit of political aims. In this case, the political goals are to give more authority back to the religion, enforce religious law, or take control over land/resources that are closely tied to that religion.

Religious extremist exist in ALL religions. Terrorism may occur as attacks on members of other religious groups (interfaith) or on people who practice the same religion (intrafaith).

Example 1: The September 11 terrorist attacks against the U.S. targeted civilians (non military people). The purpose was to strike fear and terror for the purpose of political aims – the people who committed the terror attacks (Al Qaida) were retaliating against the U.S. government for a war that occurred in the Middle East during the 1990s. Al Qaida is a group of Islamic fundamental extremist who want supreme Islamic militants who want to overthrow the corrupt “apostate”* regimes in the Middle East and replace them with “true” Islamic governments, Al Qaeda's primary enemy is the United States, which it sees as the root cause of the Middle East's problems.

*apostate means to abandon a religious belief or principle – so they want the secular (non-religious) governments replaced with theocratic (religious) governments.

Example 2: Prior to September 11, 2001, the biggest perceived threat of terrorism against the U.S. and Europe was the Irish Republican Army (IRA). The Troubles (the name given this religious conflict) occurred mostly along the border between the Republic of Ireland (predominantly Catholic) and Northern Ireland (predominantly Protestant and still part of the U.K. following Irish independence). The IRA was/is a terrorist organization that attacked civilians in the Republic of Ireland, Northern Ireland (part of the U.K.), the U.K., and mainland Europe. Their main aim was to end discrimination against the Catholic minority by the Protestant government and police force in Northern Ireland. The Troubles calmed after a tentative peace agreement was drawn between the two sides. The image above shows the aftermath of a bombing by the IRA in Belfast, Northern Ireland in 1971.